and advised Syama Prasad Mookerjee when he set up the Jan Sangh but also warned him that, as a matter of policy, the 'RSS could not be drawn into politics, that it could not play second fiddle to any political or other party, since no organisation, devoted to the wholesale regeneration of the real, that is cultural, life of the Nation, could ever function if it was to be used as a handmaid of political parties'.[46] Yet, RSS cadres formed the sinews of the Jan Sangh and were at the core of its political base, just as they provided a powerful core base for its successor.

At the same time, RSS leaders have consistently refuted talk of political ambitions. Most recently, in 2018, RSS Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat reiterated: 'There are questions regarding the political ambitions of the Sangh. Right from its inception, the Sangh had taken a conscious decision to stay away from electoral politics. No officer-bearer of the Sangh is allowed to be a member of any political party and will stay away from politics.'[47] He added, 'It is not our concern as to why other political parties do not have a large number of swayamsevaks. Why don't they (swayamsevaks) feel like going to other parties, is the question they (other political parties) need to think on. We don't ask the swayamsevaks to work for any specific party.'[48]

Yet, few would doubt that the BJP considers itself a part of the wider Sangh Parivar. It cannot be otherwise in a government led by a former RSS pracharak, Narendra Modi, and a party that has never been led by a politician who did not spend his early years with the RSS or its affiliates. Amit Shah, the co-architect of the BJP's expansion since 2014, started his career with the ABVP, as did his successor as party president, J.P. Nadda.[49]

How exactly does the RSS interface with the BJP, though? Meeting over lunch in his office in Bengaluru, I put this question to Karnataka's then deputy chief minister, Ashwathnarayan. 'The Sangh plays an important role, but we can't say we win because of it,' he responded. 'It is a separate but centralised cord between the Sangh and the BJP. The Sangh sends us people in various roles, such as organising secretary etc., in the party itself. It is an independent entity, but is also well integrated. It is time-tested …'[50]